
Following the Money: Foreign Aid and UN Voting Alignment

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Abstract How do different components of the "Bretton-Woods" liberal institutions play off each other? This paper seeks to connect the economic and political components of international institutions by determining how much, if at all, voting alignment at the United Nations General Assembly contributes to taking foreign aid from international monetary funds. This paper runs a total of 10 models, 5 of which come with a series of control and dummy variables. By seeking to connect the economic and political characteristics of liberal internationalism in mutual development and a common platform for political disputes, this paper places aid in the context of a uniquely international world.

I. Introduction

The world took a revolutionary turn in 1945. The joint defeat of Nazi Germany and Imperial Japan left almost all of Europe and East Asia decimated, and further investigation in the following years further revealed the atrocities against civilians committed by the Axis powers. While Europe was physically and economically devastated by the war, the United States emerged as a definitive victor and immediately began to help Europe rebuild itself.¹ The war not only strengthened the United States' economy, but also the Atlantic and Pacific oceans allowed Washington to avoid any confrontation on Continental soil. The 12 years before the end of the war also saw a rapidly changing political environment in the United States. Despite being an officially neutral power in the years leading up to the attack on Pearl Harbour, the United States not only signalled support for the Allied powers but also took material action to support them.² Behind the scenes, the US State Department recruited elites such as government officials, academics, lawyers, business owners, and other technocrats to

1. Henry Farrell and Abraham Newman, *Underground Empire: How America Weaponized the World Economy*, First edition (New York: Henry Holt and Company, 2023)

2. See the prologue of Arthur Herman, *Freedom's Forge: How American Business Produced Victory in World War II*, 2013 Random House Trade paperback edition (New York: Random House Trade Paperbacks, 2013).

help shape not just the war plan for the United States, but what to do once the war was over.³ During the initial years of the war, the majority of Americans were not in support of aid to Britain, but sentiment changed after the Japanese attack in December 1941.⁴ More importantly, American support for interventionism remained high even after the war ended.⁵

Akin to the "Brussels Effect" phenomenon, American economic hegemony and public support for intervention abroad provided, for the first time, the ability for the United States to not only have the economic strength to project power abroad (as they did following the First World War), but also the political will, both from the population and Congress. Apart from the Soviet Union, the Western powers also did not have any direct geopolitical adversary by 1946. Because of this, the United States and Western Powers were central to the construction of the post-war "Bretton-Woods" international order, which came with high amounts of economic and political interconnectedness.⁶ This system was strengthened during the 1950s- 70s, when almost all European powers underwent a rapid process of decolonization in Africa and Asia, leaving several new states ripe for investment and development funding.

Additionally, the Cold War between the United States and the Soviet Union resulted in the use of economic investments as a way to both win allyship from developing states and to present the material benefits of either capitalism or communism, including the respective international structures.⁷ As such, liberal institutions like the World Bank and IMF played incredibly important roles during the late stages of the Cold War in pushing developing states to adopt Western-style capitalism.⁸ These IOs continue to play critical roles in global politics well after the fall of Communism, investing billions of dollars in countries all around the world,⁹ Often in exchange for the adoption of American-style capitalism, favouring economic austerity, market-oriented policies, and reduced protectionism.¹⁰ Therefore, not only do international monetary institutions act as influential actors, but they also operate as independent arms of the

3. Stephen Wertheim, *Tomorrow, the World: The Birth of U.S. Global Supremacy*, First paperback edition (Cambridge, Massachusetts London, England: The Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2022), 8.

4. RJ Reinhart, Gallup Vault: U.S. Opinion and the Start of World War II, August 2019, chap. Gallup Vault, accessed 30 May 2026; Lydia Saad, Gallup Vault: A Country Unified After Pearl Harbor, December 2016, chap. Gallup Vault, accessed 30 May 2026

5. Lydia Saad, Americans Support Active Role for U.S. in World Affairs, April 1999, accessed 30 May 2026

6. G. John Ikenberry, *A World Safe for Democracy: Liberal Internationalism and the Crises of Global Order*, Politics and Culture (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2020), 177–212.

7. David C. Engerman, Development Politics and the Cold War, *Diplomatic History* 41, no. 1 (January 2017):1–19, accessed 30 May 2026, <https://doi.org/10.1093/dh/dhw043>

8. Ngaire Woods, *The Globalizers: The IMF, the World Bank, and Their Borrowers*, Cornell Studies in Money (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 2014), <https://doi.org/10.7591/9780801456022>

9. Foreign Direct Investment soared at the end of the Cold War, seeing constant fluctuations in response to international developments, spiking during times of international downturn. World Bank Open Data, <https://data.worldbank.org>, accessed 30 May 2026

10. See Chapter 1 of Woods, Woods, *The Globalizers*

American State.

Economic changes and battles were accompanied by several political developments and institutions that also pushed for greater international cooperation. While many of these IOs were exclusive to certain nation-states, such as the European Union, the Cominform, or ASEAN, one of the cornerstones of the new political system was the emergence of the United Nations, an international organization that consists primarily of a General Assembly and a Security Council composed of the winners of the war. While resolutions from the GA are non-binding, the Assembly still provides two useful metrics. First, voting records show the general trend of international politics, such as support for Indigenous rights,¹¹ condemnations of invasions,¹² or support for a given geopolitical event. It also helps demonstrate political alignment. During the Cold War, the Soviet and Western blocs were seeking allies throughout the world, so the UN could also be seen as a public showing of support for a state's international allegiance.¹³

The point of this paper is to bridge the politics of the Bretton-Woods system and the United Nations by asking: How does foreign aid influence state voting alignment with P5 members at the United Nations? While Liberal Internationalism does try to shift away from zero-sum politics, this clearly is not the case. Tariffs still exist, and foreign aid is often still contingent on gains for the contributing country or institution. While international banks and investing institutions are, in many cases, independent, the capitalist structure of international monetary funds favours market-based policies, which not only privatize developing economies but have also forced typically American allies in Europe to engage in austerity measures during times of economic crisis or downturn.¹⁴

Therefore, depending on how much aid a country gets, it should be joined with political support. I will argue that an influx of foreign aid will also come with alignment with the P5 countries. More specifically, I will argue that countries that take

11. United Nations Department of Economic and Social Affairs, General Assembly Adopts Annual Resolution "Rights of Indigenous Peoples", <https://social.desa.un.org/issues/indigenous-peoples/news/general-assembly-adopts-annual-resolution-rights-of-indigenous2025>, December 2025, accessed 30 May 2026

12. UN News, General Assembly Resolution Demands End to Russian Offensive in Ukraine | UN News, <https://news.un.org/en/story/2022/03/1113152>, March 2022, accessed 30 May 2026; Erik Voeten, United Nations General Assembly Ideal Points, July 2025, accessed 5 June 2026, <https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/LEJUQZ>

13. A clear case of this occurring was on October 25, 1971, when the UN General Assembly adopted Resolution 2758, which recognized the People's Republic of China as the "only lawful representatives of China to the United Nations and that the [PRC] is one of the five permanent members of the Security Council." Restoration of the Lawful Rights of the People's Republic of China in the United Nations, 1972, accessed 30 May 2026 While the vote was supported by almost all European countries, America-aligned nations in Asia, including Australia, Japan, the Philippines, and South Vietnam, voted against the resolution, whereas the communist bloc in Eastern Europe had voted unanimously in favour.

14. An example of this occurred during the 2011 Euro Crisis in Spain, in which the IMF mobilized research alongside the European Central Bank (ECB), to inject into the Spanish economy if they committed to austerity reforms. For more information, see Jean Pisani-Ferry, *The Euro Crisis and Its Aftermath* (Oxford University Press, May 2014), accessed 30 May 2026, <https://doi.org/10.1093/acprof:oso/9780199993338.001.0001>

money from Bretton-Woods institutions will also align with the liberal members of the P5. Conversely, I will also claim that nations that take less money from international funds are more likely to align with the anti-West states on the P5, China and Russia. Finally, I will also argue that states are willing to align themselves with liberal powers during times of heightened liberal hegemony, both economically and politically.

This paper will open with a discussion on the existing literature on foreign aid. While there are several arguments for the role that foreign aid plays in international politics, the majority of existing literature claims that aid is a mechanism to reward allies who are already aligned with a contributing state. Under this view, aid is a positive mechanism to ensure that small and medium powers stay alongside major powers that want to retain power over the state. Furthermore, this perspective maintains that small states approach larger states for development. Aid is used to develop new allies and increase presence internationally. This approach is especially relevant during the Cold War, in which the two global hegemonies extended economic aid throughout Africa and Asia, looking to alter the balance of power in the region.

What this stance does not take into account is the critical context of contemporary foreign aid being distributed in a uniquely international world, while also consisting of major powers that are seeking to exert national interests abroad. While other camps view foreign aid through the lens of national self-interest, they do not take into account the very new situation of having to not only deal with states for aid, but non-state actors like private corporations, NGOs, or, in the focus of this paper, international monetary institutions, all of which have different motivations but share the same trend of supporting liberal ideas. As such, aid is no longer simply a mechanism for soft power projection, but a feat of a distinct system of high amounts of political and economic interconnectedness. This paper looks at how far this interconnectedness goes and how strong this connection is.

After this, I will discuss my methodologies and variables. I will run a series of standard linear regression tests using a country-year panel with foreign aid as our dependent variable and five different primary independent variables. I will break this down later, but the reasoning for this is that determining local political and economic blocs is hard, and there are far too many to count. My IVs, therefore, will be UN-alignment between a given country and a given P5 power. While some countries, such as India, are powerful states internationally, their participation differs from that of the UNSC countries, as P5 nations *should* be basing foreign aid for the support of the Bretton-Woods system, as both the UN and foreign aid from other IOs are core elements of liberal internationalism. I will also test several control variables to ensure our results are as lean as possible. This will be a combination of both economic and political markers, such as GDP and growth, as well as alliance and colonial status.

II. Literature Review

As liberalism has continued to act as the dominant political force internationally, foreign aid serves as a contested factor in international relations scholarship. There is

extensive literature covering the importance of foreign aid in the context of international politics, as well as the place it holds in the context of foreign aid development. While early postwar scholarship often framed aid as a mechanism for economic development and international cooperation, later research increasingly emphasized its strategic and political dimensions. The central debate relevant to this paper is whether aid primarily rewards states that are already politically aligned with major powers or whether aid is deployed to cultivate future alignment and influence. This paper enters that debate by arguing that the existing literature often assumes a uniform donor strategy, while major powers may in fact use aid in different ways. By examining the relationship between UN General Assembly voting alignment and aid receipts across several major powers, this study seeks to clarify whether geopolitical alignment consistently shapes aid allocation.

Buying Votes

The first major perspective argues that foreign aid is fundamentally a tool of statecraft and direct power projection. From this perspective, donor states allocate aid to advance national interests, reward allies, and reinforce geopolitical coalitions. Aid is therefore not politically neutral, but rather reflects the strategic preferences of governments. For example, studies have found that colonial relationships and political alliances strongly shape the distribution of foreign aid, arguing that donors systematically favour countries with which they share political, historical, or strategic ties.¹⁵ Similarly, non-permanent countries serving on the UN Security Council receive substantial increases in foreign aid both from the United States and international organizations,¹⁶ suggesting that donor states use aid to reward cooperation within IOs. Additionally, studies have shown that political considerations often outweigh humanitarian need in aid allocation decisions, reinforcing the idea that aid is not apolitical but a method for liberal states to increase political legitimacy within international institutions.¹⁷

Under this perspective, UN voting behaviour becomes a proxy for political alignment. States that vote consistently with a donor in the UN General Assembly signal diplomatic support and ideological compatibility. Donors, in turn, reward those who support with greater aid flows. This literature therefore predicts a negative relationship between UN voting distance and aid receipts: the closer a country's voting behaviour is to a donor's position, the more aid it should receive.

15. Alberto Alesina and David Dollar, Who Gives Foreign Aid to Whom and Why?, *Journal of Economic Growth* 5, no. 1 (March 2000):33–63, accessed 10 June 2026, <https://doi.org/10.1023/A:1009874203400>

16. Ilyana Kuziemko and Eric Werker, How Much Is a Seat on the Security Council Worth? Foreign Aid and Bribery at the United Nations, *Journal of Political Economy* 114, no. 5 (October 2006):905–930, accessed 10 June 2026, <https://doi.org/10.1086/507155>

17. Axel Dreher, Peter Nunnenkamp, and Rainer Thiele, Does US Aid Buy UN General Assembly Votes? A Disaggregated Analysis, *Public Choice* 136, nos. 1–2 (July 2008):139–164, accessed 10 June 2026, <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11127-008-9286-x>

Do All Donors Behave the Same Way?

Although this perspective provides meaningful insight into the various factors which may contribute to a state receiving foreign aid, it makes the mistake of implicitly treating foreign aid as a uniform power base supported by Western powers. Most studies either aggregate aid flows across donors or focus primarily on democratic donors, especially the United States, which assumes that major powers use aid according to the same strategic logic. This is accompanied by a vast set of literature which argues that the United Nations, especially the P5 on the UNSC, is a cold war between the liberal and illiberal nations for pushing political goals.¹⁸

This assumption is increasingly difficult to sustain in an increasingly multipolar international system where international liberalism has faced more and more challenges. Major donors differ in their historical relationships, geopolitical objectives, and development philosophies. For example, scholarship on Chinese foreign aid suggests that China may prioritize infrastructure development, resource access, and principles of non-interference rather than ideological alignment alone.¹⁹ This goes simply beyond blank cheques of aid for development, but also the creation of new multilateral institutions capable of contesting preexisting Western-aligned institutions.²⁰ Likewise, former colonial powers such as the United Kingdom and France may maintain distinctive aid relationships rooted in historical and institutional ties.²¹ Therefore, the literature leaves an important gap: it remains unclear whether the relationship between UN voting alignment and aid allocation is consistent across different major powers. Existing theories predict that alignment should matter, but they do not adequately explain why some donors may reward aligned states while others do not.

Finally, previous literature also misses a key element of interconnectness. Previous analysis argues that aid is more likely to be given when a state votes in line with resolutions proposed by a major power,²² but this perspective downplays the importance

18. For example, Leiber argues that the UNSC lacks political independence due to the veto from the “two authoritarian—and rule-breaking—regimes, Russia and China,” generalizing the UNSC as a battleground between the monolithic liberal and authoritarian states. For more, see “Limits of Order: The U.N., the Paris Climate Accord, and the Iran Nuclear Agreement in Robert J. Lieber, *Indispensable Nation: American Foreign Policy in a Turbulent World* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2022); In another example, Williams (2019) argues that UN peacekeeping mandates contain different political actors. While peacekeeping is made up of several components, the pen-holder “P3,” nations in the UK, France, and United States act in uniformity when issuing Peacekeeping mandates. See Paul D. Williams, The Security Council’s Peacekeeping Trilemma, *International Affairs*, November 2019, iiz199, accessed 10 June 2026, <https://doi.org/10.1093/ia/iiz199>

19. Deborah Brautigam, *The Dragon’s Gift: The Real Story of China in Africa* (Oxford New York: Oxford University Press, 2009)

20. Axel Dreher et al., Apples and Dragon Fruits: The Determinants of Aid and Other Forms of State Financing from China to Africa, *International Studies Quarterly* 62, no. 1 (March 2018):182–194, accessed 10 June 2026, <https://doi.org/10.1093/isq/sqx052>

21. Carol Lancaster, France: Rank et Rayonnement, In *Foreign Aid: Diplomacy, Development, Domestic Politics* (Chicago, Illinois: The University of Chicago Press, 2007), 143–171

22. For example, Dreher, Nunnenkamp, and Thiele, “Does US Aid Buy UN General Assembly Votes?”

of middle powers and ignores the role of geopolitical blocs. In the case of the former, since the UN General Assembly is an open platform for any recognized state to table a motion, the vast majority of resolutions that are voted upon are not tabled by the major liberal powers. This would cause issues when taking in the latter, which is that states that are seeking foreign aid from major liberal powers do not just vote in favour of resolutions tabled by said powers, but would also table new motions in line with their geopolitical interests. This is increasingly relevant over the course of the Cold War and the turn of the century as the United States constructed a large set of allies in Europe, the Western hemisphere, and Asia. These countries, along with the entire international system, were then led by the United States into a state of multilateralism.²³ Additionally, the legitimacy and strength of institutions like the United Nations are dependent on the role the United States themselves play, meaning the continued participation at the UN helps maintain the integrity of liberal internationalism. As such, state participation separate from the United States is still participation that would benefit the United States, especially if it comes from middle powers like Canada, who work to push the needle on the side of and advance the interests of liberal states. Therefore, the previous set of literature maintains a narrow vision on how the UN operates and exerts political influence.

This paper addresses that gap by disaggregating donor relationships and examining UN voting alignment with multiple major powers, all of which still retain national interests. Rather than asking whether aid generally rewards allies or buys influence, the paper asks a more specific question of how foreign aid falls into major power politics more generally within the context of liberal internationalism and its extreme interconnectedness. By comparing the effects of voting alignment across several donors, this study tests whether geopolitical alignment consistently predicts aid receipts or whether donor behaviour varies on a case-by-case basis. This approach contributes to the literature by moving beyond single-donor analyses by comparing multiple major powers within the same empirical framework. In doing so, the paper bridges the divide between the “reward” and “influence” perspectives. It argues that both theories may be partially correct, but that their applicability depends on the donor under consideration. Some donors may reward existing allies, while others may use aid more flexibly to pursue broader strategic objectives.

argue that nations receive more aid when they vote in favour of US-tabled resolutions.

23. Inderjeet Parmar, ed., *New Directions in US Foreign Policy*, Routledge Studies in US Foreign Policy (London: Routledge, 2009)

III. Methodology

Variables

Our tests will contain foreign aid as our dependent variable, a number of critical primary independent variables, and a series of right-hand control variables. Data for foreign aid is taken from World Bank investments since 1975-2019, and the data will cover only this period. The reason for this is that the nature of foreign aid is dependent, in large part, on geopolitical situations. Despite being formed in 1944 at Bretton-Woods, the World Bank has undergone several changes throughout its short history, and has increasingly been at the whims of its most powerful member-states, most notably the United States.²⁴ One of the largest turning points in American domestic politics occurred during the 70s, when the joint elections of Ronald Reagan and Margaret Thatcher resulted in a pivot towards neo-liberalism.²⁵ Starting at this time, as such reflects the overlap between international institutions and domestic politics in the Western world, which would make voting in line at the UN with liberal powers is more likely. The data ends in 2019 to avoid the massive, artificial drop in aid during the COVID-19 Pandemic.²⁶

There are five primary IVs, but they all run on the same premise. Each IV will test the independent score of an observed country's voting alignment with each member of the UN Council's permanent members.²⁷ The reason for the P5 is for a few reasons. First, it is widely accepted in literature that major power politics generally include China, Russia, and the United States. The addition of France and the UK also serves as a benchmark for European regional powers that still operate as political forces,²⁸ especially in their former colonies.²⁹ This is also important for keeping in mind our findings. For example, former colonizers are also likely to sit alongside their former overlord for a number of reasons, including investments or political backing. For each of the scores, the lower the number, the more likely they are to vote alongside the country in the General Assembly.

24. Woods, *The Globalizers* 27.

25. See Part II of Paul Collier and John Kay, *Greed Is Dead: Politics after Individualism* (London] UK: Penguin Press, 2020), as well as Chapter 6 of Jefferson Cowie, *The Great Exception: The New Deal & the Limits of American Politics*, Politics and Society in Twentieth-Century America (Princeton Oxford: Princeton University Press, 2016)

26. There has since been a correspondingly large spike in foreign aid, but not all countries have been logged, and our data will, as such, not be an accurate reflection.

27. Data is taken from Erik Voeten's dataset, where dyadic scores are then shifted to a wide format. Voeten, *United Nations General Assembly Ideal Points*

28. Sophie Meunier, Is France Still Relevant?, *French Politics, Culture & Society* 35, no. 2 (2017):59–75, accessed 5 June 2026, JSTOR: 44504268

29. An example of France retaining soft power over its former colonies is seen in the case of the cultural and economic sphere of influence called "Françafrique," which has been critiqued as a case of neo-colonialism even by European allies. For more information, see Ian Taylor, France à Fric: The CFA Zone in Africa and Neocolonialism, *Third World Quarterly* 40, no. 6 (2019):1064–1088, accessed 5 June 2026, JSTOR: 26745804

I have included several variables to root out as many confounding factors as possible. Each variable as such serves the purpose of finding alternative reasons for why a country may or may not accept foreign aid from the World Bank. The first are changes in economic factors. While almost all states take money from the World Bank to some capacity, the changes in how much aid they take are dependent on changes in domestic economies.³⁰ As such, both GDP per Capita and GDP growth are both included. This way, we see both how well economic development aligns with foreign aid, while also taking into account year-over-year changes in domestic economies. I have also included population as a factor in why a country may take aid. Even in cases of high economic development, states may take international aid to fund massive works projects, the scale, speed, and frequency being largely dependent on the population's needs.³¹

Political instability is also a huge factor when it comes to aid and the flow of money into a country. As such, two variables which influence regime stability are added. The first is political instability. This is a binary variable to determine whether or not a regime or state underwent an uncharacteristically big change in status quo politics, which may have a cascading effect on how much aid they (i) want to take, and (ii) how much aid they receive from international monetary institutions. An example of this is Afghanistan, which has taken a dramatic drop in aid from the World Bank following the Taliban's takeover of the country.³² Liberal economics also suggests that investment is much more likely to take place in cases of large economic stability, with powerful state apparatuses to give clear and transparent economic data, such as the United States. The same may hold for the World Bank, which may feel less willing to give aid to countries that are not able to provide a confident ROI. On the topic of regime politics, how democratic a state is can also be a factor that plays into how much aid it can receive, so this is also taken into account.

Political instability has a secondary effect that may also have an influence on a nation-state and its potential need for aid, which is the possibility of a civil war.³³ Just as the case for private investing companies or individuals, a civil war can also have massive implications for the willingness of banks to invest in a country.³⁴ Therefore,

30. A contemporary case of this happening is in Argentina, where the country's economy saw a nosedive in the past 5 years, which has coincided with massive cash injections into the economy by the International Monetary Fund, International Monetary Fund, History of Lending Commitments: Argentina, accessed 5 June 2026

31. GDP per Capita, aid, and population are logged variables.

32. From 2010 until 2021 (except 2017 and 2018), World Bank aid flowing into Afghanistan sat above \$4,000,000,000 year over year. After reaching \$4,691,710,449 in 2021, aid under Taliban rule dropped to \$3,060,331,299 by 2023.

33. Nicholas Sambanis, What Is Civil War?: Conceptual and Empirical Complexities of an Operational Definition, *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 48, no. 6 (December 2004):814–858, accessed 25 September 2025, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0022002704269355>

34. Madhav Joshi and Jason Michael Quinn, Civil War Termination and Foreign Direct Investment, 1989–2012, *Conflict Management and Peace Science* 37, no. 4 (July 2020):451–470, accessed 5 June 2026, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0738894218778260>

this should be controlled for to make sure money is not stopping because of UN alignment, but rather for ongoing violent disputes. However, this issue is not black and white. States may still receive money if an international bank is coerced into it. This may occur when a standing government is part of a civil war and also has hegemonic powers taking its side, especially the Western world, which is in line with these banks. As such, civil war is not necessarily an indication of whether or not a country will receive aid, but we should also take into account internationalized civil wars, which have several competing parties backing them.

Alliances may also contribute to this. Especially in the neoliberal era of politics, countries continue to experience ballooning deficits, which in large part are shaped by increased military spending.³⁵ Even among long-standing alliances, both deficits and military spending have been going up for different reasons. The two Gulf Wars, and with arm-twisting from the Trump administration, as well as the ongoing conflict between Russia and Ukraine since 2014, have required expanded spending of both major powers, as well as small and medium powers in these alliances. Additionally, since military alliances are ideologically driven, states are more likely to align with the P5 if they are part of or lead an alliance. Therefore, three alliances are included in the data: NATO (1949-Present), the Warsaw Pact (1955-1991), and the Commonwealth of Independent States.³⁶

Another cause for not accepting foreign aid would be the receipt of aid from other countries directly. This is especially relevant given how connected the world is economically. However, states are still often in research or economic agreements with their former overlord, such as the British Commonwealth or Françafrique. A strong economic sphere combined with political pressure may lead to states not needing to take or not being allowed to take foreign aid, rather opting to receive national aid, which then translates to political backing at the UNGA. Therefore, a binary variable will be added to test whether or not being a former colony would influence voting alignment, while also not having a disproportionate influence on how much aid is being taken. This would only impact major colonial empires, the United States, as well as Australia, which temporarily occupied and operated Nauru and Papua New Guinea. Since our data begins after 1975, most, if not all, states had decolonized, and the colonial era had concluded. Since colonial empires have developed to be more aligned with the Western world today, I will also include this as a variable to test.

Finally, democratic states have not emerged alone, but are generally part of a large wave of democratization globally. Therefore, when changes in the status of global liberalism occur, it is possible that states are more likely to engage or disengage with liberal institutions. Furthermore, when power-centres themselves do better or worse, cascading effects may result in support for international monetary institutions, with

35. John Paul Dunne and Eftychia Nikolaidou, DEFENCE SPENDING AND ECONOMIC GROWTH IN THE EU15, *Defence and Peace Economics* 23, no. 6 (December 2012):537–548, accessed 5 June 2026, <https://doi.org/10.1080/10242694.2012.663575>

36. I have folded in all Russian-based alliances after the Warsaw Pact into the CIS.

states being more open to foreign aid or investment through them.³⁷ This will be the final control variable, and will also be a binary one.

Testing

I will run a series of standard linear regression tests using a country-year panel model. I will first run five tests just with our DV and UNA scores (one test for each P5 country). After logging our findings, I will then run five more tests incorporating the control variables, testing for new hypotheses and findings. The point of our controls is to root out alternative reasons for investment apart from UN votes.

Theories and Hypotheses

Based on our discussion so far and the existing research on the topic, we should expect to see a correlation between the amount of aid a country receives and its alignment with the liberal P5 members in the USA, UK, and France. Therefore, I will hypothesize the following:

H0: *There is no relationship between an intake of foreign aid and UN voting alignment.*

H1: *An increase in foreign aid will also result in higher alignment with the liberal powers on the P5.*

Since the UN is, ultimately, another group for political friction, it is also possible, if not likely, that disagreements within the P5 would mean that siding with the liberal powers would counter the non-liberal members in Russia and China. As such, I also posit that:

H2: *An increase in foreign aid will also result in lower alignment with the non-liberal powers on the P5.*

Our last five models will also look for the impact that hegemonic shocks have on the willingness to take foreign aid. In essence, what we could assume is that a massive increase in democratic countries internationally would force other countries to engage with democratic institutions, if not domestically, but internationally, which should also benefit the liberal members of the P5 in voting patterns. Therefore, I will also claim that

H3: *Nations are more likely to align with the liberal members of the P5 during cases of hegemonic shocks.*

Our findings should lead us to accept all three hypotheses while also being able to confidently reject the null hypothesis.

37. This variable is based off Seva Gutinsky's "Hegemonic Shocks" concept, in which rapid changes of domestic and international politics promote massive democratic or anti-democratic waves, ultimately stemming from changes within hegemonic powers. For more information, read Seva Gutinsky, *Aftershocks: Great Powers and Domestic Reforms in the Twentieth Century*, Princeton Studies in International History and Politics (Woodstock, Oxfordshire: Princeton university press, 2017)

IV. Findings

I ran a series of standard linear regression tests using a country-year panel model. First, individual UN alignment scores are provided in **Table 1** and visualized in **Figure 1**. Models 1 through 5 test each score without control variables, and are only testing for the null and the first 2 hypotheses. We find positive relationships with the liberal P5 countries, with significance at the 0.01 level with the United States and France, and at the 0.05 level with the UK. Conversely, robust findings are present with China and Russia, finding a negative relationship at the 0.01 level. As such, **H0** is rejected as significance is proven. However, **H1** and **H2** are also rejected as the increase in aid coincides with an increase in voting alignment with Russia and China.

Table 2 brings in our control variables and looks to test all four hypotheses. Looking at the findings, our coefficients and significance change dramatically. **H0** is rejected as Russia, France, and the UK remain statistically significant. With that said, the United States and China lose significance. As such, **H1** and **H2** are both partly accepted. Finally, testing for changes in the hegemonic order does not yield significant results, nullifying **H3**. While our hypotheses are proven *more* correct in models 6-10, we can help identify other factors into what contributes to an intake of foreign aid. I will, as such, dedicate the remainder of this section to breaking down each variable that is of interest.

The first statistically significant variable is democracy. Across all five models, a positive relationship is proven at the 0.01 level, indicating that higher levels of democracy mean that a state is also more likely to align with all five P5 nations. There are a number of reasons why this may be the case. The first is the important recognition that General Assembly votes are non-binding, and as such, otherwise anti-Western states (such as those on the P5) may likely vote in favour of resolutions proposed or supported by democratic countries. Similarly, countries with a higher support for democratic norms would not want to compromise their standing at the United Nations, nor would they want to de-legitimize the institution, and as such would support resolutions even if they were proposed by opposed states.

Population and economic factors are, in almost all cases, relevant factors. Greater populations are more likely to receive more aid, which could be tied to a variety of reasons, including the one theorized earlier that a state apparatus might not be able to keep up with booming populations in national investment. As may be expected,

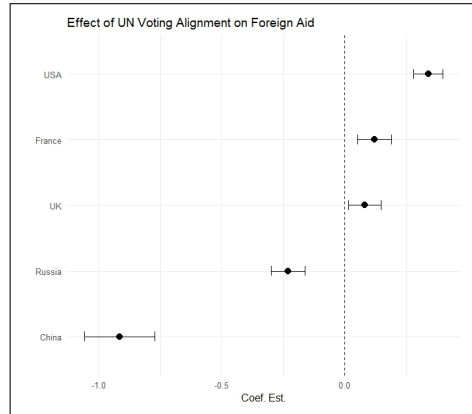


FIGURE 1. *Effect of Foreign Aid on UN Voting Alignment*

TABLE 1. *Foreign Aid and UN Voting*

	Dependent variable:				
	(1)	(2)	log.aid (3)	(4)	(5)
USA Voting Alignment (<i>usa.una.dist</i>)	0.339*** (0.030)				
UK Voting Alignment (<i>uk.una.dist</i>)		0.080** (0.034)			
France Voting Alignment (<i>fra.una.dist</i>)			0.121*** (0.035)		
China Voting Alignment (<i>chn.una.dist</i>)				-0.915*** (0.073)	
Russia Voting Alignment (<i>rus.una.dist</i>)					-0.231*** (0.035)
Constant	17.885*** (0.090)	18.882*** (0.076)	18.820*** (0.071)	19.409*** (0.065)	19.311*** (0.044)
Observations	5,636	4,473	4,473	1,115	4,204
R ²	0.022	0.001	0.003	0.124	0.010
Adjusted R ²	0.022	0.001	0.002	0.124	0.010
Residual Std. Error	1.545 (df=5634)	1.565 (df=4471)	1.563 (df=4471)	1.540 (df=1113)	1.564 (df=4202)
F Statistic	129.201*** (df=1;5634)	5.668** (df=1;4471)	12.080*** (df=1;4471)	158.108*** (df=1;1113)	43.813*** (df=1;4202)

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

a negative relationship exists with GDP per Capita all across the board, indicating that lower economic capacity is associated with increased aid. With the exception of model 9, GDP growth is also tied to increases in aid, though the models do not conclude the degree to which this is the product of the aid itself, if at all.

Variation exists over the extent to which instability and civil war play into aid. Instability is significant in models 6 and 8 at the 0.05 level, and it shows significance at the 0.1 level in models 7 and 10. Finally, there is no meaningful impact in model 9. Overall, regime instability does have a slight impact. Civil war is much more robust through all models, with significance at the 0.01 level in models 6, 7, 8, and 10. As is the case for regime stability, model 9 does not yield any significant findings.

Being a former colony also has a robust positive relationship with taking aid, being significant at the 0.1 level in model 6, and at the 0.01 level across all others. We can possibly tie this to the fact that large portions of post-colonial states fell under the umbrella of Soviet influence, such as Cuba or Indonesia, and as such would be more likely to be more vocally antagonistic to the United States. The question then begs as to how different the liberal P5 countries vote amongst each other to make a

TABLE 2. *Foreign Aid and UN Voting (With Controls)*

	Dependent variable:				
	log.aid				
	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)
USA Voting Alignment (<i>usa.una.dist</i>)	0.043 (0.028)				
UK Voting Alignment (<i>uk.una.dist</i>)		-0.343*** (0.035)			
France Voting Alignment (<i>fra.una.dist</i>)			-0.284*** (0.036)		
China Voting Alignment (<i>chn.una.dist</i>)				0.002 (0.066)	
Russia Voting Alignment (<i>rus.una.dist</i>)					-0.121*** (0.027)
Democracy Score (<i>democracy.score</i>)	0.089*** (0.006)	0.102*** (0.007)	0.110*** (0.007)	0.177*** (0.013)	0.135*** (0.007)
Logged Population (<i>log.pop</i>)	0.464*** (0.009)	0.536*** (0.010)	0.531*** (0.010)	0.462*** (0.012)	0.507*** (0.010)
Logged GDP (<i>log.gdp</i>)	-0.0001*** (0.00000)	-0.00005*** (0.00000)	-0.00005*** (0.00000)	-0.0001*** (0.01001)	-0.00004*** (0.00000)
GDP Growth (<i>gdpgrow</i>)	0.011*** (0.002)	0.009*** (0.002)	0.009*** (0.002)	0.003 (0.006)	0.007*** (0.002)
Political Instability (<i>polinst</i>)	-0.200** (0.085)	-0.178* (0.092)	-0.188** (0.093)	0.099 (0.161)	-0.166* (0.099)
Civil War (<i>civil.war</i>)	0.340*** (0.052)	0.306*** (0.050)	0.303*** (0.050)	-0.020 (0.117)	0.276*** (0.051)
Former Colony (<i>frmr.col.bin</i>)	-0.082* (0.046)	0.491*** (0.049)	0.445*** (0.049)	0.344*** (0.089)	0.254*** (0.049)
Hegemonic Shock (<i>hegemonic.shock</i>)	0.031 (0.050)	0.100* (0.053)	0.071 (0.053)	0.101 (0.096)	0.050 (0.055)
Constant	11.398*** (0.158)	10.738*** (0.161)	10.643*** (0.161)	10.762*** (0.244)	10.668*** (0.170)
Observations	4,270	3,285	3,285	787	3,059
R ²	0.543	0.620	0.616	0.749	0.611
Adjusted R ²	0.542	0.619	0.615	0.746	0.610
Residual Std. Error	1.037 (df=4260)	0.961 (df=3275)	0.965 (df=3275)	0.841 (df=777)	0.982 (df=3049)
F Statistic	561.384*** (df=9;4260)	593.800*** (df=9;3275)	584.306*** (df=9;3275)	258.083*** (df=9;777)	533.215*** (df=9;3049)

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

statistical difference between them. Our other models yield more robust findings, so there should be a discussion as to what would lead post-colonial states to vote in line with France and the UK but not the United States. Finally, hegemonic shocks are not significant, meaning periods of democratic waves do not influence voting alignment or aid taken.

V. Discussion

Despite our hypotheses being partially proven correct, our findings still provide interesting results to help form a fruitful discussion. Once controls were added, we found that indicators such as colonial history, economic development, and civil war status were critical elements of what makes a country take aid from international monetary funds and also vote alongside the P5. One of the most rapid changes seen between the first and second batch of models was the relationship seen in voting alongside Britain and France, going from a significant positive relationship to a robust negative one. We can assume the initial theories were correct that the major colonial powers would rather retain national control over their former colonies, and as such disincentivize them from having to take international aid.

Another derived conclusion from our findings is that the rejection of the idea that the United Nations is a platform for open political disputes between liberal and illiberal powers. As seen in our second series of tests, when everything is controlled for, states that receive aid are more likely to vote not just alongside the UK and France, but also with Russia. The logical extension of this argument is that there may not be a large gap in voting between the liberal and illiberal powers as a bloc, but rather between national interests, rejecting the monolithic perspective of standard liberal literature.³⁸ As such, the UN should not be seen as a place exclusively for ideological combat, but rather as a platform for states to exert national self-interest. In the context of the P5 countries, aligning with what would otherwise be seen as adversaries helps shape support for popular positions, participation in various committees, or political support for states involved in a resolution. For small and medium powers, shifting alignment between major states has no direct material consequences due to the non-binding nature of GA resolutions.

What our findings have proven to us is that when other streams of investment are taken into account, states are more likely to vote in line with both liberal democracies and autocracies when receiving foreign aid. Overall, our findings have revealed two major things. First, the number of nations which take money from the International

38. For example, Leiber argues in favour of US supremacy by saying, "The U.N.'s ability to function is frequently blocked by the opposition of two authoritarian—and rule-breaking—regimes, Russia and China, through their ability to veto resolutions of the Security Council." While this claim is being made in the context of Security Council resolutions, General Assembly resolutions should still reflect similar friction between ideological blocs, Lieber, *Indispensable Nation*

Monetary Fund is extremely vast. It is not only liberal democracies or transitional regimes which take foreign aid, but rather any country that needs it. In tandem, if these institutions feel as though investments will yield a positive ROI, aid will follow suit. It also reveals the non-partisan nature of the UN and the mutual-sum game of international liberalism. Rather than having to align hard with one ideological bloc over another, the UN serves as a platform for countries to exert national interests while still staying in line with multiple power centres, emphasizing the various decentralized channels through which states can engage with each other internationally.

Conclusion

This paper has sought to find a connection between various elements of liberal internationalism. More specifically, it looked for the connection between the two major political and economic components of the liberal world order in the United Nations and international aid. This paper ran 10 models, the first 5 running a direct regression between our independent and dependent variables, and 5 more models adding in various control variables, taking into account different reasons for alternative foreign investment. While our first set of tests indicated that states that receive aid are more likely to vote with the illiberal powers of the P5, the implementation of variables revealed that states are more likely to vote across the board, voting with Russia, France, and Britain. A few meaningful theories can be drawn from our findings. First, since General Assembly resolutions are non-binding, there is less of a consequence to not picking a "side" in terms of general voting, even if it exists in the same realm as obtaining material aid, emboldening the claim that the UN lacks the political power it needs to maintain its legitimacy. This paper has also demonstrated the separation between the different elements of liberal internationalism. Despite institutions and nation-states being increasingly intertwined, the political and economic systems still act separately from each other.

Future research should be done on the subject to determine the factors that contribute to soft power in the modern era. Despite taking money from American-aligned monetary institutions, the UN is still an area for both plentiful disagreement with the United States and agreement with American adversaries. As such, there should be a discussion about the strength or relevance that the UN holds in the context of soft power. Other elements, such as national investment or direct state-to-state diplomacy, may act as more reliable metrics for what dictates the acceptance of foreign aid, leaving the UN, at least in the General Assembly, as a place to discuss internationally recognized common issues.

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